



The Two Lives of Mark Zuckerberg

Connecting the world was easy, staying liked during that was not.

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There are different ways to do innovation. You can plant a lot of seeds, not be committed to any particular one of them, but just see what grows. We go mission-first, then focus on the pieces we need and go deep on them and be committed to them.

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There's a line from The Dark Knight that fits Mark Zuckerberg better than almost anyone else in tech: you either die a hero or live long enough to see yourself become the villain. Most founders get one signature act and then fade into board meetings or yacht photos. Zuckerberg got both halves of that arc in full public view, and he's still building through it, still in the room, still the one signing off on the next bet. He didn't lose the plot somewhere along the way. He just stayed in the story long enough for the story to turn on him.

The hero years

Facebook in 2004 was not supposed to change anything outside a few Ivy League dorm rooms. It started as a directory, a way to put faces to names at Harvard, and the genius wasn't really the code. It was the restriction. You needed a .edu email address to get in, which made the platform feel exclusive and trustworthy at exactly the moment the rest of the internet was anonymous and chaotic. That early instinct, that scarcity and identity build trust faster than openness does, is one Zuckerberg would later

abandon completely, and arguably never recover the upside of.

The real unlock came in 2006 with the News Feed. People hated it on day one. There were protest groups, petitions, op-eds calling it an invasion of privacy. And then nobody logged off. That gap between what users say they want and what they actually can't stop using became the Zuckerberg playbook before anyone had a name for it, and it's a playbook half of the modern internet still runs on.

The acquisitions were the part that actually proved he understood the game better than his critics gave him credit for. Buying Instagram for a billion dollars in 2012, when it had thirteen employees and absolutely no revenue, looked reckless. Buying WhatsApp for nineteen billion in 2014 looked outright insane to most of the financial press at the time. Both turned out to be among the shrewdest plays in tech history, not because Zuckerberg out-engineered anyone, but because he read where attention was migrating before the market had a model for pricing it. By the time Facebook went public in 2012, it wasn't a website anymore. It was infrastructure for a meaningful